



**TETHERED OR NOT... THE CHOICE IS
COMPLEX. VERY COMPLEX.**

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hen it comes to audio, the debates are endless, given the subjective nature of the likeness of devices for many. However, across categories of products, there is one debate that has remained a constant, and that is of wired versus wireless audio. With the advancements in technology over the years, the difference has slimmed down. However, there is still enough that stands on both sides of the debate, which keeps the fire alive, and audiophiles divided. Here, I bring for you a look at both sides of the debate. No personal bias or opinions, just pure objectivity and facts both in favour of and against wired and wireless audio. Have a look –

QUALITY OF AUDIO

When we talk wired audio, the idea of having to look for CODECs support, latency, signal strength, and interference (for the most part), goes out of the window. All you need to think about is

the way in which you will be connecting your source device to the output. With that out of the way, all you need to think of is in what way you will be connecting your source device to the output.

Now, before the purists come at me, yes, I know, in high-fidelity applications and devices, the interference caused by other electromagnetic signals present around the source device and the wires carrying the signals can cause an issue. However, it is minimal, in comparison to what wireless devices generally tend to encounter. The overall signal strength that wireless audio transmission can carry pales in comparison to that of wireless audio.

Coming back to the quality of audio, most wireless devices, especially the ones that are available with Bluetooth as the only connectivity option, come with SBC and AAC. Both these CODECs are limited in terms of the bit-rates that they are capable of carrying. SBC can do up to 345kbps and AAC can transmit up to 320kbps. Not to mention the issues

with the compression and latency issues that come in. There are devices that support high quality CODECs as well, which I covered in my article about buying headphones and soundbars. However, those come in high-end devices, which are priced higher than most consumer wireless audio devices. When you are talking about wired audio devices, even the simplest audio devices do not have issues in carrying signals with much higher bit rate than the above-mentioned CODEC.

However, for that to happen, we are limited by the source device that is connected to the wired audio device that you are working with. And, that brings us to the topic of convenience. I will circle back to this later in the article. For now, let's focus on the quality of audio. When working with wired devices, the major thing that you need to take care of, is the fact that whether your source device will be able to power your output device or not. If the output device is underpowered, then you will notice